PROCESS IMPROVEMENT CASE STUDY

Oregon Unemployment Identity Verification

A real world claimant journey used to evaluate process clarity, accessibility, exception handling, and operational rework

CASE STUDY FOCUS | What the claimant experiences • Where the process creates friction • How the workflow could be improved

Purpose

This case study follows my own Oregon unemployment identity verification experience beginning September 15, 2026. I started documenting it because I was actively trying to comply and still could not tell what was supposed to happen next or how to fix the process when something went wrong. The purpose is not to evaluate the Oregon Employment Department as an organization. It is to use one documented claimant journey to show where a necessary fraud prevention process creates confusion, repeated work, access barriers, and delays.

Everything in this report comes from what I personally saw, received, submitted, attempted, or was told directly by OED or WorkSource staff. Where a statement reflects staff guidance rather than a written notice, I identify it that way. The analysis stays with that evidence: what I was asked to do, what happened when the normal path failed, which contact channels actually worked, and what the process required from me in time and effort.

1. Executive Summary

Identity verification is part of the unemployment process and serves a fraud prevention purpose. In this case, the failure was not a refusal to verify identity. I repeatedly tried to complete the process, supplied multiple forms of identity documentation, asked what else was required, and continued meeting my work-search obligations. The claim still reached a denial stating that identity had not been confirmed. By October 15, after the denial was reversed and I met with WorkSource Oregon, the initial claim process finally appeared to be complete and payments were expected to begin. The first payment finally hit the bank on October 19th.

The central problem shown by this case is not the absence of capable staff. The strongest assistance I received came from a WorkSource employee once I reached an in-person human channel. The failure was the routing and technology around that assistance. One late mailed verification notice derailed the claim, the digital system did not provide a reliable recovery path, telephone access consumed more than 14 hours across two days without reaching a representative, previously submitted documents were requested again, and the system later generated contradictory instructions about whether identity verification was complete. The WorkSource visit also revealed a live-person chat option that had not been apparent in the claimant-facing information I had seen.

Design principle: the claimant should not have to reverse engineer the process in order to comply with it.

A clearer process would reduce both claimant effort and agency rework. At filing, the claimant should be shown the complete sequence, whether each stage requires claimant action or agency processing, what communication to expect, when to follow up, and what to do if the normal path fails. A simple flow chart with a visible fallback route - including how to reach live assistance - could have prevented much of the confusion and rework documented here. A claimant should not have to become the project manager of their own claim just to learn who owns the next step.

2. Process Objectives

Program control objective	Claimant experience objective
Confirm the identity of the person filing the claim.	Understand exactly what verification is required and how to complete it.
Prevent fraudulent or duplicate claims.	Have secure alternatives when the standard verification path cannot be completed.
Maintain adequate documentation and auditability.	Know when documents were received, whether they were accepted, and what remains.
Route exceptions for review.	Have a visible exception path rather than repeatedly trying unrelated contact channels.
Protect public funds.	Avoid unnecessary delays and rework for legitimate claimants.

3. Documented Claimant Journey

The timeline below is the evidence record for this case study. It documents what happened, what I did in response, and what each step required. New events can be added chronologically without changing the structure of the analysis.

Date	Stage	Documented event	Claimant action	Process observation
September 15, 2026	**Claim filed**	Laid off in a reduction in force. Filed an unemployment claim through Frances Online and included the RIF letter as supporting documentation.	Created a job search tracking spreadsheet the same day and had already begun applying for work.	The claim began with immediate claimant action: the claim was filed, supporting documentation was supplied, and the job search was already underway. What was missing was a clear explanation of the identity verification sequence that would follow.
September 15, 2026	**Requested process expectations**	Received one portal letter directing me to look for work. Frances indicated that communications occur through the portal, but the letter did not explain the broader claim/verification sequence.	Sent a message asking what process expectations I should anticipate and what would happen next.	The first question was basic: what should I expect next? The available information did not answer that question in a way that let me plan or know whether I should act or wait.

Date	Stage	Documented event	Claimant action	Process observation
September 18, 2026	**Verification status remained**	The identity verification message remained and I could not see a way to submit the weekly job search information.	Sent another message asking why verification was stuck and whether anything was required from me, supplied my job search documentation as an attachment with this message. Called for assistance; the recorded path repeated information and disconnected because a claim had already been filed.	The status blocked progress but did not tell me whether the next move belonged to me or to OED. I was already trying to comply, but I could not tell what compliance required.
September 25, 2026	**Repeated request for assistance**	The same verification issue continued and earlier questions had not produced guidance.	Sent another request for information and again supplied my weekly job search documentation as an attachment. Again attempted telephone contact without reaching a person.	Repeated requests for basic guidance created more claimant work without resolving the issue.
September 28, 2026	**Verification letter delivered after deadline**	A mailed identity verification letter was handed directly to me by the mail carrier. It was dated September 17 and stated a September 25 deadline. The code was unusable when received, and the notice warned that benefits could be denied if the requirement was not completed by the due date. I live in a rural community served by one regular postal worker; that worker had been on vacation for two weeks, which delayed the time-sensitive notice.	Immediately began trying available telephone options to reach a person because the mailed instruction could no longer be completed.	A time sensitive requirement depended on a single mail-delivery path outside the claimant's control. In this case, an ordinary staffing event in a rural community was enough to make the verification credential unusable before it arrived. The process had no automatic protection for a predictable delivery failure.
September 28, 2026	**Telephone escalation attempts**	Telephone contact did not provide a reliable path to a representative.	Spent approximately six hours repeatedly calling. Calls involved long holds, disconnections, and restarting the process without reaching a person who could resolve the issue.	Six hours spent trying to reach help is six hours not spent searching for openings, tailoring applications, researching employers, or preparing for interviews. The contact process had already started competing with the job search.
September 28–29, 2026	**Contact Us generated active correspondence**	Used the public Contact Us route. It required email verification and subsequent electronic access. This route produced the most responsive communication to date and led to multiple exchanges.	Responded to requests and supplied identity documentation.	This was the first channel that produced an actual exchange with a person. It moved the issue forward, but each response introduced only the next piece of the process rather than explaining the full path.
September 29, 2026	**Additional identity documentation supplied**	OED stated that a passport submission could not be accepted because it needed to be signed. The passport was already signed; I submitted another copy intended to make the signature clear, plus a bank statement as additional identity evidence and the late delivered letter for documentation.	Asked for confirmation of receipt, whether the documents satisfied the current requirement, and whether anything further was needed.	The document issue created another cycle of submission and review even though the passport was already signed. Clear submission standards and a complete document checklist could have prevented that extra work.
September 29, 2026	**In person verification question**	OED stated that in person verification cannot occur until a letter is issued and that the letter may provide a post office option or WorkSource/re employment interview option.	Asked for confirmation that no additional in person action could be taken until that letter was issued and requested clarification of the expected path.	I was trying to follow the instructions, but the next action still depended on another letter or system event I could not trigger myself.

Date	Stage	Documented event	Claimant action	Process observation
September 29, 2026	**Documents added to benefit issue / system status dependency**	OED confirmed the documents were uploaded to the benefit issue. Staff stated the issue could not be vacated until it entered "failure to provide" status, expected the following Tuesday. The staff member assigned the issue to themself and stated they would return to vacate it the following week.	Retained the response as documentation and took no additional action because the message indicated the next step depended on an internal system status change.	The documents were in the benefit issue and a staff member had taken ownership, but I still had no clear confirmation that the identity requirement was satisfied. I relied on the written statement that the issue would be revisited after the system changed to 'failure to provide' status.
October 5, 2026	**Job search information supplied**	Current job search information was submitted while the identity issue was still unresolved.	Continued documenting work search activity and supplied the information through the available communication path.	The job search continued even while significant time was being spent trying to resolve the claim itself.
October 5, 2026	**Denial appeared / appeal requested**	A denial notice dated October 6 became available in Frances on October 5. It stated that benefits were denied beginning October 5 because identity had not been confirmed. The notice said Frances Online could be used to request a hearing, but I could not find a direct appeal option for this decision.	Submitted a written appeal/review request through the available Contact Us route and retained the confirmation.	The claim reached a denial after identity documents had already been uploaded to the benefit issue and after a staff member had said the issue would be revisited once the system status changed.
October 6, 2026	**Promised follow up date / prior conversation closed**	This was the Tuesday the staff member had identified as the point when the issue was expected to enter 'failure to provide' status and could be vacated. By then, the prior correspondence thread could no longer be continued because the response path had expired or closed.	Attempted to continue the conversation and confirm whether the promised work had been completed, but there was no way to reply to the person who had taken ownership of the issue.	A staff owned issue reached the promised follow up date without a usable way for the claimant to continue the same conversation or confirm whether the work was completed. Context and continuity were lost at the point they were most needed.
October 6, 2026	**Full day telephone escalation**	Telephone contact still did not provide access to a representative. The appeal/hearing number routed back into the same hold pattern rather than creating a separate path.	Began calling at approximately 7:55 a.m. and spent more than eight hours on hold or retrying calls. The automated system disconnected calls multiple times. No representative was reached. Combined with the earlier six hour day, more than 14 hours had been spent trying to reach OED by telephone across two days.	More than 14 hours of unsuccessful telephone contact is not only a service problem. It is time taken away from finding openings, completing applications, networking, preparing for interviews, and doing the work required to return to employment.
October 6, 2026	**Remote contact paths no longer usable**	The online message route would not allow another message or reply. A website message stated that the post office verification option was not available.	Considered the in person option, but travel requires fuel at a time when there is no current income and that fuel is needed for job interviews and other essential travel.	A contact option is not meaningfully accessible simply because it exists. When phone and online routes do not produce help, the remaining path can shift the cost of the process onto the unemployed person who is trying to use it.
October 8, 2026	**Appeal Follow Up Attempted**	Continued attempting to follow up on the appeal and unresolved identity-verification issue after the prior communication path would not allow another message to be sent.	Attempted another written follow up through the available contact process.	Even after an appeal/review request had been submitted, continuing the conversation required finding another way back into the system rather than simply replying to the existing issue.
October 9, 2026	**Escalation to state representatives**	With the identity-verification issue still unresolved and normal OED contact methods not producing a resolution, I emailed my state representatives requesting assistance.	Explained the unresolved claim issue, repeated attempts to reach OED, and the barriers preventing the claim from moving forward.	The issue had reached the point where assistance outside OED was sought because the normal claimant communication paths had not resolved it.
October 9, 2026	**Legislative office response**	Received an email from Rep. McIntire's office confirming that my email had been forwarded to the Oregon Employment Department.	Retained the response and waited for OED follow up.	A legislative office became another route for attempting to get the unresolved claim in front of OED.
October 12, 2026	**Job search information supplied**	Current job search information was submitted while the identity issue was still unresolved.	Continued documenting work search activity and supplied the information through the available communication path.	The job search continued even while significant time was being spent trying to resolve the claim itself.

October 13, 2026	**Identity documents requested again by Hearings**	Sarah from the Hearings Admin Team requested identity documents for manual verification, asking for either two primary documents or one primary and two secondary documents. The same identity documentation had previously been supplied to Kris.	Resubmitted my driver's license, signed passport, and current bank statement. Referenced prior correspondence with Kris and asked for confirmation that the documents were received and that manual verification was complete.	Documents that had already been provided to OED and confirmed as uploaded to the benefit issue had to be submitted again to another OED team, creating another cycle of duplicate work and delay.
October 13, 2026	**Manual verification submission confirmed by the system**	The new identity-document submission was accepted by the system and assigned a confirmation number, which I retained as proof of submission.	Saved the confirmation number as proof of submission.	The claimant again had to preserve independent proof that documents had been supplied because the same documents had already been requested and submitted previously.
October 13, 2026	**ID verification denial updated**	After I resubmitted the requested identity documents, Sarah from the Hearings Admin Team confirmed in writing that she had updated the ID verification denial and that the change should appear in my account after the system updated the following day.	Saved the written confirmation and waited for the system update.	The same identity documents that had already been supplied earlier led to same-day action once they reached a staff member who could complete the manual verification and update the denial. The extended delay occurred before the issue reached that point.
October 14, 2026	**Identity denial canceled / successful verification confirmed**	OED issued a notice stating that the October 6 identity-verification decision had been sent in error, that benefits were being allowed after successful identity verification, and that the prior administrative decision was canceled. The notice stated that no additional action was required on that issue.	Saved the notice as the first clear written confirmation that identity verification had been completed.	After weeks of uncertainty, the claimant finally received an unambiguous written statement that identity verification was complete. That clarity arrived only after a denial, appeal activity, repeated document submissions, and escalation.
October 14, 2026	**Conflicting in-person identity notice**	A separate notice issued the same date required a reemployment orientation and in-person identity verification by October 27 or benefits could be denied, despite the other notice stating that identity had already been successfully verified and no additional action was required.	Preserved both notices and sought written clarification rather than relying on an assumption about which instruction controlled.	Two system-generated notices issued on the same date gave opposite instructions about the same requirement. Contradictory notices create unnecessary claimant risk, additional contacts, and potentially unnecessary travel.
October 14, 2026	**Weekly claims became available / manual re-entry required**	After the identity issue was corrected, Frances allowed prior weekly claims to be filed. Each direct employer contact had to be typed into the system manually. The system did not accept the job-search documentation I had already maintained and supplied, and the entry fields did not allow copy and paste.	Spent several hours entering the prior weekly claims, retyping work-search information, and submitted the required first-effective-week no-earnings questionnaire.	The system created another layer of rework after the claim was unblocked. Information already documented and previously supplied had to be manually re-entered one item at a time, taking additional time away from the job search.
October 15, 2026	**WorkSource Oregon appointment / effective assisted service**	Met with WorkSource Oregon. The employee was extremely helpful, reviewed the situation, and showed me that the chat interface can connect a claimant with a live person by typing into the chat. Before this visit, I had seen the interface as a limited chatbot that returned scripted answers, often directing me back to telephone or other unhelpful instructions. The employee also advised me that my former employer had not responded and that OED had to allow a three-week employer response period before moving forward.	Used the appointment to address the remaining initial-process questions and understand what had delayed the claim. I left with the understanding that the initial process was finally complete and that payments should now begin.	This was the clearest evidence in the case that assisted human service can work very well once the claimant reaches it. The major failure was discoverability and routing: a useful live-chat path and effective WorkSource assistance existed, but neither had been surfaced early enough to prevent weeks of rework, a denial, an appeal, and repeated escalation. The employer-response delay was also not visible to the claimant while it was occurring.
October 19, 2026	**First payment was deposited**	The bank finally showed a payment made.	No further action required.	

4. Where the Process Creates Friction

Friction point	Why it matters	Improvement
No complete roadmap	The claimant receives individual instructions without a simple view of the entire verification sequence, making it difficult to know what to expect or when something has gone wrong.	Publish a claimant facing verification roadmap at filing.
Ambiguous status meaning	A verification status can remain visible without saying whether the claimant should act, wait, or contact someone. That uncertainty creates repeated checking and follow up.	Label every status 'Action required' or 'No action required' and explain the next trigger.
Unanswered process questions	Repeated questions about what to do next did not produce timely guidance, so the claimant had to keep trying new channels and preserve a record of every attempt.	Use standard process expectation responses and escalate unanswered time sensitive questions.
Mail dependent deadline	The mailed notice arrived after its stated deadline, making the required code unusable before the claimant had a chance to act.	Use delivery safe deadlines and a one click late/expired notice exception.
Telephone access friction	Telephone service required hours of waiting and repeated restarts without reliably reaching a person. More than 14 hours were spent across two days without a representative.	Use callback or queue preservation, publish realistic wait information, and provide a clearly identified exception path that can actually advance the claim.
Sequential requests	Identity documents that had already been supplied and confirmed as uploaded were later requested again by another OED team, creating another submission and review cycle.	Show previously accepted documents across teams and request only what is actually missing.
Channel dependency	Frances, Contact Us, email authentication, telephone service, and in person assistance exist as separate channels, but they do not help if each path eventually reaches the same unresolved issue or becomes unavailable.	Design and test a complete non digital/assisted pathway.
Document availability	Identity rules must also work for people who do not have a passport, bank statement, lease, reliable internet, transportation, or other resources that make the standard path easier.	Publish a clear alternate document decision tree and assisted verification route.
Conversation continuity	A staff member took ownership and stated they would return on a specific date, but the conversation could no longer be continued when that date arrived and the issue remained unresolved.	Keep staff owned conversations open until the promised action is completed, or transfer the full history and ownership to another staff member without making the claimant restart.
Claimant time burden	Hours spent on hold, sending messages, resubmitting documents, tracking deadlines, saving proof, and rebuilding context are hours not spent looking for work.	Measure claimant time as a process cost and design callbacks, status updates, and evidence receipts to reduce repeated claimant labor.
Appeal path overlap	The appeal/hearing telephone number routed into the same hold pattern, and the account did not show a direct appeal option for the decision even though the notice listed Frances Online as an appeal method.	Provide an appeal path that is visibly available, produces immediate confirmation, and does not depend on the same failed service queue.
Cost of in person fallback	When remote channels fail, travel becomes the practical fallback. For a person with no current income, fuel used to seek claim help may be the same fuel needed to attend interviews.	Maintain a complete remote exception path so an unemployed claimant is not required to spend scarce transportation resources simply to learn what action remains.
Evidence burden	The claimant must preserve dates, messages, confirmation records, document submissions, call attempts, and staff promises because a later denial or appeal may depend on proving what already happened.	Give claimants a visible case history with document receipts, contact history, ownership, promised follow up dates, and appeal status in one place.

Friction point	Why it matters	Improvement
Hidden live assistance	A WorkSource employee showed that typing into the chat interface can connect the claimant to a live person, but that capability was not apparent from the claimant-facing information I encountered. A support channel that exists but cannot be discovered is functionally unavailable to many users.	Label live-chat escalation clearly in the interface and in every notice that directs claimants to online help.
Contradictory notices	On October 14, one notice stated that identity verification was successfully completed and no further action was required while another notice required in-person identity verification by October 27 or benefits could be denied.	Suppress obsolete notices when a requirement is satisfied and run conflict checks before sending new claimant instructions.
Manual re-entry / no copy and paste	Once weekly claims became available, previously documented work-search activity had to be retyped manually, one employer contact at a time, and the fields did not allow copy and paste.	Allow reuse, upload, or import of existing work-search records and permit normal copy-and-paste entry.
Rural mail single point of failure	The verification path depended on a time-sensitive mailed code. In a rural community served by one regular postal worker, a two-week vacation delayed delivery beyond the deadline and derailed the normal claim path.	Do not make a single mailed credential the only workable trigger. Use delivery-safe deadlines and immediate digital or assisted recovery when mail is late.
Invisible employer-response wait	At WorkSource, staff advised that my former employer had not responded and that OED had to allow a three-week response period before moving forward. That waiting period was not visible to me while I was trying to determine why the claim was stalled.	Show when the claim is waiting on an employer, the response deadline, and whether the claimant needs to do anything during that period.

5. Digital Access Is a Process Dependency

Multiple channels only create access if at least one of them can actually move the claim forward. In this case Frances, Contact Us, email authentication, telephone lines, and an in person office all existed. By October 6, the prior conversation could no longer be continued, another online message could not be sent, and both the regular phone route and the appeal/hearing number fed into the same hold pattern. A website message also stated that the post office option was not available. The remaining in person option required fuel and transportation from a claimant with no current income. A channel can exist on paper and still fail to provide practical access.

- A claimant may have no home internet, limited cellular data, or only a smartphone, which makes long forms, uploads, and document management much harder.
- Even with internet access, a claimant may still need a scanner or camera, email, passwords, multi factor authentication, document storage, and the ability to move between several systems.
- A telephone number does not solve the access problem if a claimant can spend an entire workday on hold and still never reach a person.
- A rural claimant may face both connectivity and transportation barriers. Requiring an in person visit can mean spending fuel or travel money that is also needed for interviews and basic needs.
- An assisted channel should be able to complete or meaningfully advance the process. Redirecting the claimant to another unavailable channel simply transfers the problem without resolving it.

The WorkSource visit exposed an important contrast: the human assistance itself was effective once I reached it. The employee was able to explain the process, identify information that had never been visible to me, and show me a live-person chat path that I did not know existed. The problem was not simply a shortage of channels; it was that the useful channel was hidden behind an interface that appeared to be only a limited chatbot.

A digital system should make escalation more obvious as complexity increases. If a claimant asks the chatbot a question it cannot answer, repeats the same issue, or reports an expired verification code, the system should clearly offer live chat or assisted service rather than repeating the same scripted directions. A hidden escalation path does not reduce call volume or claimant effort if people do not know it exists.

6. Identity Documents and Real World Claimant Circumstances

Fraud controls require credible identity evidence, but a usable process also has to account for the documents and resources real people actually have. In this case, document availability was not the barrier: I supplied a driver's license, a signed passport, a current bank statement, and the late delivered verification letter, and OED confirmed that the identity documents were uploaded to the benefit issue. The identity issue still remained unresolved and later produced a denial.

- Not every claimant owns a U.S. passport.
- A claimant may have valid identification but no lease, utility account, or similar address document in their own name.
- A person may be unbanked and therefore unable to produce a conventional bank statement.
- Housing instability, a recent move, a shared household, or temporary living arrangements can make address documentation difficult.
- A Social Security number used in the application is not necessarily enough for later verification. When stronger evidence is required, the alternate path should be explained before the claimant reaches a deadline.
- The answer is not to weaken identity standards. It is to make acceptable document combinations clear and provide a workable assisted path when the standard combination is unavailable or has already been supplied but the issue remains unresolved.

7. What the Process Required in Practice

By October 15, resolving the claim had become a separate workload alongside the job search. I had to track dates, deadlines, message threads, submitted documents, call attempts, confirmation records, promised follow up, appeal activity, contradictory notices, weekly claims, and later communication with WorkSource and my state representatives because each item could become necessary to show that I had complied. None of that work moved me closer to a job, but failing to document it could make it harder to challenge a denial or understand what remained.

The practical result was repeated claimant labor and avoidable agency rework. The process eventually moved forward, but only after the normal path failed and multiple alternate paths had to be tried. The documented process included all of the following:

- A time sensitive verification code arrived by mail after its deadline and could not be used when received.
- Identity documents were supplied, confirmed as uploaded, requested again by another team, and resubmitted. The denial was then updated the same day the duplicate documents reached the Hearings Admin Team.
- A staff member took ownership and said they would return when the system reached a specific status, but the prior conversation could no longer be continued when that follow up date arrived.
- More than 14 hours were spent attempting telephone contact across two days without reaching a representative, and the appeal/hearing number routed back into the same hold pattern.
- When the online message route also stopped accepting another message and the website stated the post office option was unavailable, the practical fallback was an in person trip that required fuel needed for interviews and other essential travel.
- On October 14, OED issued one notice stating that identity verification was successfully completed and another notice requiring in-person identity verification by October 27, creating two opposite instructions on the same date.
- Once weekly claims finally became available, previously documented work-search information had to be manually retyped into Frances. Direct contacts could not be copied and pasted or uploaded from the records I had already maintained and submitted.
- At WorkSource on October 15, a helpful employee showed me that the online chat can reach a live person and explained that part of the delay was a three-week employer response period because my former employer had not responded. Neither fact had been visible to me while I was trying to understand why the claim was stalled.
- The WorkSource experience demonstrated that the assisted-service side of the system can work well. The operational problem was getting the claimant to that effective assistance before weeks of delay, rework, denial, appeal activity, and escalation occurred.

8. Proposed Future State Claimant Journey

Stage	Claimant facing design
1. Claim submitted	Immediate confirmation includes a simple identity verification roadmap: what happens next, what the claimant should receive, and when to follow up.
2. Verification initiated	Portal or letter states plainly whether the claimant must act now or wait for agency processing.
3. Expected communication checkpoint	Claimant is told what should arrive, when it should arrive, and exactly where to go if it does not.
4. Verification action	Claimant completes the standard digital, mailed, or assisted verification step and receives proof that it was received.
5. Automatic receipt/status	System confirms receipt and says either 'under review - no action required' or identifies the precise missing item and how to correct it.
6. Exception handling	Late mail, an expired code, inaccessible location, rejected document, unavailable contact channel, technology barrier, or contradictory notice has a named exception route. If automated help cannot resolve the issue, the system clearly offers live chat or WorkSource assisted service that can actually advance the case.
7. In person verification, if required	If an in person step is required, the claimant receives the trigger, locations, what to bring, and a remote or assisted alternative when travel is not reasonably available.
8. Verification completion	Status clearly states that identity verification is complete, the issue is closed, and what happens next with the claim.
9. Staff owned exception or appeal	When a staff member takes ownership or an appeal is filed, the claimant receives confirmation, the conversation remains available, prior context is preserved, and a clear next checkpoint is provided. If the claim is waiting on an employer or another external response, that dependency and deadline are visible to the claimant.

9. Example: The Information That Could Prevent Most Confusion

WHAT HAPPENS NEXT → WHAT YOU SHOULD RECEIVE → DO YOU NEED TO ACT? → WHAT TO DO IF IT DOESN'T HAPPEN

Stage	Expected event	Your action	If something goes wrong
After filing	Identity verification begins.	No action unless the status says action is required.	If no next instruction appears by the stated checkpoint, use the clearly identified exception contact rather than guessing which channel to try.
Letter/code expected	Instructions arrive by the stated method.	Complete the listed step.	If the notice arrives late or expired, report that it was received too late to use and receive a replacement or alternate path without restarting the entire process.
Documents submitted	Receipt is acknowledged and review begins.	Wait while status says agency review.	If rejected, the response states exactly why, lists acceptable replacements, and preserves proof of what was already submitted.
In person step	System explains when/where the step becomes available.	Attend with the listed documents.	If transportation, location, technology, or document access prevents completion, use the stated alternate route without being sent back to the same failed channel.
Staff follow up promised	A staff member accepts ownership and gives a follow up date.	Wait until the stated checkpoint; the conversation remains open.	If the action is not completed, the same thread can be escalated with the full history intact.
Phone or online help needed	Claimant reaches a callback, queue, visible live-chat option, or written support path that can access the case.	Use one clearly identified contact route and receive confirmation that the request is in queue or connected to a live person.	If automation cannot answer the question or the channel is unavailable, the interface clearly escalates to live chat or WorkSource assisted service instead of sending the claimant back to the same failed queue.

10. Accessibility Stress Test

A process should be tested for whether a person can actually complete it, not simply whether a phone number, website, or office technically exists.

- Claimant with broadband, computer, smartphone, email, driver's license, passport, bank account, and reliable transportation - and whether the process still works when an exception occurs.
- Claimant with only a smartphone.
- Claimant without reliable internet or email.
- Claimant with limited digital literacy or difficulty navigating multiple portals, passwords, uploads, and message systems.
- Claimant with state identification but no lease, utility account, or bank statement in their own name.
- Unbanked claimant or claimant experiencing housing instability.
- Rural claimant with limited transportation or no money available for fuel to reach an office.
- Claimant whose mailed verification notice arrives after the deadline.
- Claimant who is actively job searching but must spend hours or entire days trying to resolve the unemployment process itself.
- Rural claimant whose mail delivery depends on a single local route or limited carrier coverage, where an ordinary absence can delay a time-sensitive government notice beyond its deadline.
- Claimant who can use a website but does not know that a live-person support option exists because the interface presents itself as a limited chatbot and the escalation path is not labeled.

11. The Unequal Burden of Process Failure

My experience also raises a broader concern about accessibility and equity. I approached this process with reliable internet access, a computer, transportation, the necessary identification documents, and professional experience navigating complex administrative systems. I also had enough financial stability to continue pursuing a resolution while benefits were delayed.

Despite those advantages, completing identity verification required weeks of repeated effort, extensive documentation, unsuccessful attempts to obtain assistance, and escalation beyond the normal process.

For someone without those same resources, the consequences could be substantially greater. A person relying on unemployment benefits to pay rent, purchase groceries, or maintain transportation may not have the time, technology, financial flexibility, or administrative knowledge needed to navigate repeated failures.

This case does not establish how frequently other claimants experience these barriers. It does, however, demonstrate how much effort a single claimant may need to expend when the standard process fails.

A public benefits system should not require exceptional persistence, technical proficiency, or personal resources simply to complete a routine eligibility requirement.

12. Measures of a Better Process

- First path identity verification completion rate.
- Median time from claim filing to identity verification completion.
- Percentage of mailed verification notices reported received after or near their actionable deadline.
- Repeat contact rate before verification completion.
- Average claimant contacts, staff touches, and claimant hours spent trying to resolve verification issues.
- Document rejection and resubmission rate by rejection reason.
- Telephone abandonment or disconnection rate, average wait time, and percentage of callers who actually reach a representative.
- Percentage of explicit claimant questions answered in the first substantive response.
- Number of cases sitting in a status where no claimant action is available, including cases with staff ownership but no completed follow up.
- Completion rates by digital, telephone, paper, in person, and assisted verification pathway, including time taken away from job search activity to complete those pathways.
- Percentage of chatbot sessions that surface or connect to live assistance when automation cannot resolve the issue.
- Percentage of claimants who can identify the correct exception path without making a telephone call or visiting an office.
- Number of contradictory or obsolete notices generated after a requirement has already been satisfied.
- Average time and number of claimant actions required to recover from a late or unusable mailed verification notice.
- Percentage of claims waiting on employer response where the claimant-facing status clearly shows that dependency and response deadline.

13. Process Improvement Recommendations

Recommendation	Operational intent
Publish the roadmap first	Tell claimants the verification sequence at filing instead of revealing it one request at a time or forcing them to search for instructions after a problem occurs.
Use action oriented statuses	Every status should say who owns the next action, what the claimant should do now, and what triggers the following stage.
Create checkpoints, not promises	The agency does not have to promise a resolution date, but it should give a real checkpoint and a usable follow up path if the expected event does not happen.
Protect against delivery failure	A claimant should not lose the ability to comply because a mailed credential arrives after its deadline. Late delivery should trigger an immediate replacement or alternate path.
Consolidate known requirements	When human review identifies multiple document requirements, communicate them together and confirm what has already been accepted.
Build a true exception path	Late mail, expired codes, rejected documents, unavailable locations, failed phone access, closed message threads, and inaccessible document combinations should all have defined routes that can move the case forward.

Recommendation	Operational intent
Make assisted service complete	Telephone or in person assistance should be able to advance the case rather than redirecting the claimant back to a channel that has already failed.
Design automation around exceptions	Use automation to reduce routine work, but automatically escalate repeated contacts, stalled statuses, expired deadlines, and contradictory signals instead of making the claimant start over.
Measure claimant effort	Track repeat contacts, resubmissions, abandoned calls, closed threads, and claimant hours as process costs - not only the final verification outcome.
Preserve conversation ownership	When a staff member says they will return to an issue, keep the thread open until the work is completed or hand it off with the full history, owner, and promised follow up date visible.
Protect job search time	Use callbacks, queue preservation, clear written status updates, and consolidated requests so resolving an unemployment claim does not consume entire workdays that should be spent finding work.
Make appeals independently usable	A formal appeal route should be easy to find, accept the request without requiring a live representative, immediately confirm receipt, and not send the claimant back into the same failed support queue.
Keep a visible claimant record	Show document receipts, contact history, current owner, promised follow up dates, and appeal status in one place so the claimant does not have to build a separate evidence file just to prove what already happened.
Do not make travel the only fallback	Maintain a complete remote exception path before requiring an in person visit, especially when the claimant has no current income and transportation resources are also needed for interviews.
Make live help discoverable	If live chat is available, label it plainly and surface it automatically when the chatbot cannot resolve a question, when the same issue is repeated, or when a verification exception is reported.
Show external waiting periods	When the claim is waiting on an employer or another outside party, show that status, the response deadline, and whether the claimant needs to do anything. Do not make the claimant interpret silence as a possible failure to comply.
Prevent contradictory notices	Use system checks to suppress obsolete instructions and flag conflicts before notices are released, especially when one record says a requirement is complete and another still tells the claimant to complete it.
Reduce duplicate data entry	Allow claimants to reuse or import documented work-search activity and permit standard copy and paste. Do not require information already supplied to be manually retyped without an operational reason.
Run a focused 90-day claimant-journey redesign	Map the end-to-end process, identify the highest-volume failure points, surface live assistance, publish a one-page flow chart with fallback routes, test rural and digital exceptions, and remove avoidable rework. The first objective should be a process that a claimant can understand without reverse engineering it.

14. Conclusion

The strongest lesson from this case is that the people and the process are not the same thing. Once I reached WorkSource Oregon on October 15, the employee was extremely helpful. He explained information that had not been visible in the online process, showed me that the chat interface could reach a live person, and helped me understand why part of the claim had been waiting. I left with the understanding that the initial process was finally complete and that payments should begin. The assisted service worked; reaching it was the problem.

The cost of the routing failure was substantial. A time-sensitive verification notice arrived after its deadline because a rural mail route had been interrupted by an ordinary two-week carrier absence. From that single failure followed repeated messages, document submissions and resubmissions, more than 14 hours of unsuccessful telephone contact across two days, an identity denial, appeal activity, legislative escalation, contradictory notices, and several more hours manually re-entering weekly work-search information that had already been documented. All of that administrative work competed directly with the job search.

The improvements proposed here are not about weakening identity verification or assuming that every delay can be eliminated. They are about building recovery into the process. A claimant should receive a simple roadmap, know when the agency is waiting on someone else, see a clearly labeled live-assistance option, and have an immediate exception route when mail, technology, or another channel fails. The WorkSource experience suggests that much of the human capability already exists. The opportunity is to connect that capability to the claimant earlier, reduce reliance on a brittle computer workflow, and stop making people discover the process only after something has gone wrong. The claim was ultimately resolved, with the first unemployment payment received on October 19, 2026, more than a month after the initial claim was filed on September 15.

Methodology

This case study is based on contemporaneous records I maintained during the claim, including dated correspondence, mailed notices, document submissions, contact attempts, weekly claim activity, and actions taken in response to agency instructions. It also includes information provided directly by WorkSource staff during the October 15 appointment; those points are identified as staff guidance rather than independently verified policy. Personal identity documents and private claim identifiers are not included in the public portfolio version.